



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 18

KENTUCKY

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Kentucky's family courts and child-welfare system.

70

KENTUCKY FAMILIES ON RECORD · 98
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 18 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
MAY 13, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
34 OF 120

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

KENTUCKY AT A GLANCE.

Across 70 Kentucky families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 98 69 of 70 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$116,250 median across 35 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 18 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 42.9% 30.0% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 70	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.4	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 69 of 70	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 34

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Kentucky families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF KENTUCKY FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	42	\$10,000	\$98,718	\$4,146,160
Lost Wages	34	\$17,500	\$69,656	\$2,368,300
Other Court Fees	27	\$1,000	\$12,107	\$326,900
Therapy / Evaluations	34	\$1,375	\$8,934	\$303,770
Reunification Services	22	\$500	\$7,498	\$164,950
GAL Fees	27	\$2,000	\$7,969	\$215,150
Asset Loss ¹	31	\$29,874	—	—
Median Family Burden (35 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$116,250	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$29,874) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		18	1.5 yrs
Mean months lost		38	3.2 yrs
Total across all families		2,033	169.4 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · KENTUCKY

Most families documenting in Kentucky are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		29	41%
Not provided		20	29%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		11	16%
Case closed: within last 2 years		6	9%
Active case: progress being made		2	3%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		42	60%
Family Court Only		14	20%
Unknown		9	13%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		4	6%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		1	1%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

Over 10 years		12	17%
1 – 3 years		12	17%
Less than 6 months		11	16%
5 – 10 years		10	14%
3 – 5 years		8	11%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		22	31%
50/50 Joint		13	19%
Visitation Only		13	19%
Children in Foster Care		10	14%
Full Custody		6	9%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Jefferson		8	11%
Fayette		3	4%
Clark		2	3%
Lincoln		2	3%
Garrard		2	3%
Daviess		2	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		20	29%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		17	24%
Other		5	7%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		5	7%
Environmental/Poverty-Related (Lack of housing, utilities, etc.)		4	6%

04 PARENT VOICES — KENTUCKY

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Kentucky comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



GALs or any third party appointed personnel cannot legally force you to pay for their services without a contract. Most are wholly inadequate to provide therapeutic or decide any sort of attachment bond between you and your children. Attorneys are not better parents or mental [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

They ignored my children being sexually abused by my family because they all know each other. They completely ignored all the evidence and won't terminate grandparents rights. Took my children when nothing was wrong.

— KENTUCKY PARENT · SHANNA

MORE VOICES FROM KENTUCKY

They have destroyed my children and family. They almost took my and their father's life

— PAMELA

In East KY, stands a judge who "fights" abuse by keeping kids there, where small town politics rule not truth and evidence. Our child, is a victim, the people meant to protect are actively hurting him.

— JOHN

Protected my abuser while causing me and my children more trauma.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has destroyed the lives of me and my children. My children currently live with their abusive father and I have no contact.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I don't even care what they done to me. They nearly destroyed my child's life. They've destroyed the lives of so many children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This has been very detrimental to my children's mental, emotional, physical wellbeing, as well as mine.

— SAMANTHA

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



absolutely ripped my children away due to another person while i was at work

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ive been slandered, harassed and stripped of my parental rights by the courts. Ive been mentally abused by the system to the point of being suicidal. Thats just the tip of the iceberg.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The Family Court has destroyed my entire life, separated me from my children and I was their primary caregiver, litigated me into destitution and I am at imminent risk to lose my home from delays and stalling. The judge is incompetent. Opposing counsel is now an accomplice- if [...]

— JENIFER

It has caused severe trauma and loss, emotionally and financially for my family. The excessive stress has also manifested as physical illness.

— VIVIAN

The system has mentally and emotionally abused my children. Broken families and it affects everyone

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system ruined my life and stole my relationship with my children, completely

— KEVIN

This wicked system has stolen something priceless that my son and I can never get back. It has inflicted trauma and irreparable harm for no legitimate reason. This injustice is inhumane.. we feel like we are in the twilight zone.

— EMILY

Tore our family apart. Broken our children

— ASHLEY

Destroyed us, mentally, emotionally & financially!

— BRITNY

“The system has emotionally drained us.” The system took my baby when I fought so deeply.”

— TRAVONNA

They destroyed me and my family

— DANNY

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



My daughter is traumatized Omy whole family is, she believes shes never coming home and wants to give up

— VELENA

‘Through prolonged delays, silenced voices, blocked access to the courts, and unchecked power, the system dismantled our family not by justice, but by process—leaving my children separated and a parent unheard.’

— JESSICA

CPS didn’t just intervene in my family, they disrupted our bond, our stability, and our ability to heal together.

— SAMANTHA

It destroys a person and health and emotions etc.

— HALLIE

I’m walking a very lonely path. My hope is that one day the system can protect the protective parent and stop violating our rights

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I will sit up to be arrested by my family on the restitution charge that I had already paid. Nobody came and got my children at the very rest so they put them in foster care for dependency. I have now completed my case plan and they still will not give me my kids.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My story is I tried to break a cycle of abuse with me and my parents couldn't stand that and neither could my siblings so anytime I was happy here they come! I thought my kids would be off limits but I was wrong! The abuse and torture me and my kids have endure is something most [...]

— TAWNIA

My relationship with my childs father has been destroyed. My relationship with my family has also been obliterated because of cps and the courts playing us against each other.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Traumatized my kids, their therapist stated she needed to teach my 10yo to be a survivor, to be able to survive the abuse by his dad bc the court keeps giving him unsupervised visitation. Medical issues, anxiety, ptsd, issues with schools that were supposed to be their safe [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



My children have intentionally and forcefully been neglected and abandoned by removing me from their life.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Severed what was a strong bond between my children, myself, and my fiancée. Prevented healthy discussion and understanding for my kids to understand that they were not abandoned by me and that this is not a reflection of their worth.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Im still in therapy. Now in spravato and emdr, my youngest has abandonment issues and major anxiety, now pooping his pants, he has major separation anxiety from me. My older sons were completely brain washed. My ex now has control over their minds as well as they are very [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Alienation of the children from a loving father and stepmother

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Creating turmoil where there wasn't any. Maddening progress that wears you down until you feel like leaving this earth. Never give up

— AMBER

The system has been nothing but destructive force in our lives. The harm will never be fully repaired.

— JASON

There is no constitutional reason to remove a parent from a child. All allegations of child abuse should be tried in criminal court, perjury should carry a high price. Abolish this Racketeering across our country.

— JESSICA

Stole precious time, created permanent psychological scars that can heal but will never go away, and completely broke our trust in the government.

— DEIDRA

System failed me. Removed my son after 7 years of being sole custody caring parent. Court actors played together to corrupt the system. I lost 18 months parenting time. I want to expose them all so no parent go through this ever again !

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Evidence was suppressed, profits maximized at the expense of 3 children's precious bond with their mother. Drug addict, batterer given full custody even after he let our baby overdose on his drugs and she needed narcan to survive death. He didn't pay child support and harassed [...]

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Tore us apart forever

— RICHARD

The system has accepted my ex wife's EPO against me for her and the children that was written in retaliation for me being done with her after 17 years of trying. It's been 8 months of the system separating me from my 5 children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

scared our minds forever,family problems with inlaws too much too list

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Destroyed. My sons are now brainwashed and alienated from me when I was the one accused of coaching and alienating them from their father because the didn't want to live with him.

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Cause great damage. These people do not know what they are doing....

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removed me from my children's daily lives during the exact years their clinical records now show caused them measurable, documented harm: separation trauma, maximum-score separation anxiety, and a mood disorder diagnosed by two independent licensed clinicians who both concluded [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

51 Kentucky parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 46 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — KENTUCKY

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Kentucky families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

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— SHANNA

GALs or any third party appointed personnel cannot legally force you to pay for their services without a contract. Most are wholly inadequate to provide therapeutic or decide any sort of attachment bond between your and your children. Attorneys are not better parents or mental health providers, and the majority of "therapists" are not qualified for high conflict cases, especially if alienation or attempts at false abuse allegations are made. Judges who sign off on motions without due process hearings from these self appointees are lazy and incompetent. Please find a new job, this is not a good fit for you.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— PAMELA

In East KY, stands a judge who "fights" abuse by keeping kids there, where small town politics rule not truth and evidence. Our child, is a victim, the people meant to protect are actively hurting him.

— JOHN

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— JENIFER

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

removed me from my children's daily lives during the exact years their clinical records now show caused them measurable, documented harm: separation trauma, maximum-score separation anxiety, and a mood disorder diagnosed by two independent licensed clinicians who both concluded the cause was the separation itself, not my conduct. Every month I was restricted to supervised visitation while that unamended registry KARES listing cost me employment and income was a month my children went without their mother during a period that cannot be recovered — and the record of what that absence did to them is now in signed clinical notes from providers who had no connection to this case and no reason to reach any conclusion except the one the evidence gave them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my relationship with my children, used me for title four funding as a baby, then targeted my children because they knew I had no family. My six year old daughter (who i am just fine to parent) doesn't know her siblings, and they have been turned against me. Its like experiencing pain and hunger for 10 years straight with no relief in sight.

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No steps towards reunification with my children despite completing my case plan for over a year. Visits have stayed at minimum since they were taken 2 hours every other week, I've requested increased visitation and in-home visitation supervised or unsupervised. Called urgent care with no release of information signed, violating my privacy.

— SARAH I

I have no faith in the system. My son is now 34. He returned at 18 but is not the same. I've had more kids. The anxiety is unreal. I have attachment issues. I cant be hugged or touched without teasing. I am afraid to truly love them. I fear unexpected calls or knocks on the door. If they are late getting home I panic.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The biggest losses we've been separated from the children continuously one of them hasn't spoken to us in over 5 years and she's now past the age of 18 thousands and thousands were spent for reunification everything was lost the home the children the business all equity and everything lost over 50 years old and trying to start from scratch it was moved to a new County and it's still going on who knows how many much more it's going to cost have to go prosane no money left

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

51 full approved Kentucky comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Kentucky report comes from Kentucky respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Kentucky — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 70 Kentucky families reporting here are not the universe of Kentucky families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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